of the 20 assembly seats allotted to it in 2021. "The BJP needs us more than we need them," says AIADMK spokesman Kovai Satyan. EPS knows the BJP's hope of winning a few seats rested largely on its alliance with the AIADMK. Thus, by severing ties with it now, he's trying to ensure that even in the eventuality of a rapprochement, the BJP is in no position to bargain for more than the five seats allotted to it in 2019. Aware of this ground reality, the BJP, too, is being guarded in its response to the AIADMK announcement, with state leaders who welcomed the end of the alliance being asked to retract their statements.

For now, the AIADMK is upbeat about performing well in the 2024 LS polls. They contend there is a strong anti-incumbency mood against the NDA as well as the DMK in the state. They draw inspiration from 2014, when the party contested the LS polls alone and bagged 37 of the 39 seats in Tamil Nadu—though repeating that feat in the absence of a charismatic supremo like Jayalalithaa will be a huge challenge.

Some feel the BJP can woo the AIADMK's anti-EPS factions led by OPS and T.T.V. Dhinakaran, besides the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK), the Indhiya Jananayaka Katchi and the Thamizhaga Munnetra Kazhagam led by John Pandian. "Now, it has the option of leading a third front, and may even win a couple of traditional seats in the southern districts in a three-cornered contest that it was more likely to lose in direct contests," says Moorthy. In the next few months, its national high command has to decide whether to reconcile the differences with the AIADMK or put money behind Annamalai's claim that the party is strong enough to win 25 Lok Sabha seats in Tamil Nadu. ■

KASHMIR ENTENTE

A THAW STARTS IN SRINAGAR

By Moazum Mohammad

After a long forced hiatus, during which Kashmir's politics was in semi-eclipse, a few developments have got everyone watching with interest. On September 22, All Parties Hurriyat Conference chairman Mirwaiz Umar Farooq walked free after four years under house arrest and was allowed to lead the prayers at Srinagar's historic Jama Masjid. Two other clerics were freed before him, from Jammu's Kot Balwal jail. Salafist preacher Mushtaq Ahmad Veeri and Barelvi cleric Maulana Abdul Rashid Dawoodi had been booked under the Public Safety Act in September 2022 for "instigating youth". The arrest of Dawoodi, chief of the Tehreek-e-Soutul Awliya who has a huge sway in south Kashmir, was even noted by the US Commission for International Religious Freedom as one that had to do with his "religious leadership role".

It was on August 4, 2019, that the Mirwaiz—one of Kashmir's most prominent separatist faces and also its chief cleric—was detained in a pre-emptive measure. That was a day before the Centre turned Article 370 into a dead letter. This August, as he completed four years of being cooped up at his home in Srinagar's Nigeen, the Mirwaiz sent a legal notice to the government against his "illegal confinement". His counsel then filed a writ petition challenging the detention in the Jammu and Kashmir High Court, which sought a government response within four weeks from September 15. However, he was released ahead of the hearing. As for Veeri and Dawoodi, the court quashed their detention on September 8, but the political mood had swung around to that already, with



PEOPLE'S LEADER
Mirwaiz Umar Farooq at Srinagar's Jama Masjid, Sept 22

ABID BHAT